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Optimizing Error Messages: The Impact of Optimized Error Messages in Teaching F#

Bachelor's Thesis

by

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February 22, 2025

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Declaration of Authorship

I hereby declare that the work I have submitted with the title „Optimizing Error Messages: The Impact of Optimized Error Messages in Teaching F#“ was independently written by me. I have fully disclosed all sources and aids used and have identified as quotations all passages of the work — including tables and figures — taken verbatim or in substance from other works or the internet, indicating the respective sources.

Kaiserslautern, on 22.2.2025

Jakob Meyerhöfer

Abstract

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetuer adipiscing elit. Etiam lobortis facilisis sem. Nullam nec mi et neque pharetra sollicitudin. Praesent imperdiet mi nec ante. Donec ullamcorper, felis non sodales commodo, lectus velit ultrices augue, a dignissim nibh lectus placerat pede. Vivamus nunc nunc, molestie ut, ultricies vel, semper in, velit. Ut porttitor. Praesent in sapien. Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetuer adipiscing elit. Duis fringilla tristique neque. Sed interdum libero ut metus. Pellentesque placerat. Nam rutrum augue a leo. Morbi sed elit sit amet ante lobortis sollicitudin. Praesent blandit blandit mauris. Praesent lectus tellus, aliquet aliquam, luctus a, egestas a, turpis. Mauris lacinia lorem sit amet ipsum. Nunc quis urna dictum turpis accumsan semper.

Summary

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Contents

1. Introduction **1**
1.1. Motivation . . . 1
1.2. Research Problem and Objectives . . . 1
1.3. Research Questions . . . 1
1.4. Research Structure . . . 2

2. Related Work **3**
2.1. Challenges for Novice Programmers . . . 3
2.2. Role of Error Messages in Learning . . . 3
2.3. Existing Approaches to Improving Error Messages . . . 3
2.4. Educational Feedback Theories . . . 3

3. Analysis of Previous Semester Data **5**
3.1. Data Collection and Methodology . . . 5
3.2. Compilation Success Rates . . . 7
3.3. Test Pass Rates . . . 8
3.4. Insights and Patterns . . . 9

4. Problem Analysis: Issues with Existing Error Messages **13**
4.1. Examples of Current Error Messages . . . 13
4.1.1. Example 1 — `digitSum` . . . 14
4.1.2. Example 2 — `sortedDigits` . . . 17
4.2. Information Gaps in Error Outputs . . . 20
4.3. Challenges for Novices in Deriving Test Information . . . 20

5. Assertify: A Library for Improving Error Messages **21**
5.1. Objectives and Design of Assertify . . . 21
5.2. Implementation Details and Wrappers . . . 21
5.3. Error Message Improvements (Before and After Comparisons) . . . 22
5.3.1. Example 1 — `digitSum` . . . 23
5.3.2. Example 2 — `sortedDigits` . . . 24
5.4. Usability and Design Considerations . . . 24

6. TODO: Further Methodology (unclear what comes next) **27**

7. Evaluation and Results **29**
7.1. Evaluation Methodology . . . 29
7.2. Metrics for Success . . . 29
7.3. Quantitative Analysis . . . 29
7.4. Qualitative Insights . . . 29
7.5. Comparison to Previous Results . . . 30

8. Conclusion **31**
8.1. Summary of Contributions 31
8.2. Key Findings 31
8.3. Suggestions for Future Work 31

9. Discussion **33**
9.1. Interpretation of Results 33
9.2. Impact on Learning Process 33
9.3. Strengths and Limitations of Approach 33
9.4. Recommendations for Future Development 33

List of Figures **35**

List of Listings **37**

List of Tables **39**

A. My Code **41**

B. My Ideas **43**

Bibliography **45**

1. Introduction

1.1. Motivation

Understanding and interpreting error messages is a fundamental challenge for novice programmers. Error messages serve as an essential form of feedback, helping programmers diagnose issues in their code. However, standard error messages, particularly those generated by compilers and testing frameworks, are often cryptic, overly technical, and difficult for beginners to decipher.
As a tutor, I frequently observe students struggling with these messages, unsure of what went wrong and how to fix their code. Instead of guiding them toward a solution, poorly structured error messages often lead to frustration and trial-and-error debugging. This hinders the learning process and increases the time required to grasp key programming concepts.
To address this issue, this thesis explores how improving error messages can enhance the learning experience for novice programmers. By providing clearer, more structured feedback, we aim to help students understand their mistakes more effectively, ultimately leading to a more efficient and engaging learning process.

1.2. Research Problem and Objectives

The primary problem this thesis addresses is the difficulty novice programmers face when interpreting error messages. Standard compiler and testing framework messages often assume prior knowledge, making them inaccessible to beginners. This can lead to confusion, incorrect assumptions about the problem, and inefficient debugging strategies. The objectives of this research are as follows:

- Analyze the impact of traditional error messages on the learning process.
- Develop a modified approach that enhances the clarity and usefulness of error messages.
- Evaluate whether improved error messages lead to faster learning and better debugging strategies among students.

To achieve these objectives, I have developed a test class that extends standard error reporting by adding a compact summary of test results. This modification aims to provide clearer feedback, helping students identify and resolve issues more efficiently.

1.3. Research Questions

This thesis seeks to answer the following key research questions:

- How do traditional error messages impact the learning process of novice programmers?
- What specific issues do students encounter when interpreting standard error messages?
- Can modified error messages improve comprehension and debugging efficiency?
- How does structured feedback affect students' ability to correct their mistakes?

By addressing these questions, this research aims to provide insights into the effectiveness of improved error reporting and its potential role in programming education.

1.4. Research Structure

This thesis is structured as follows:

- **Chapter 2: Related Work** – Reviews existing research on challenges faced by novice programmers, the role of error messages in learning, and previous attempts at improving error feedback.
- **Chapter 3: Analysis of Previous Semester Data** – Presents an analysis of past student submissions, including compilation success rates and test pass rates, to identify common issues.
- **Chapter 4: Problem Analysis** – Examines specific problems with existing error messages, including real-world examples and gaps in the information they provide.
- **Chapter 5: Assertify — A Library for Improving Error Messages** – Introduces and explains the implementation of Assertify, a tool designed to enhance error feedback.
- **Chapter 6: Methodology** – Describes the approach taken to evaluate the effectiveness of improved error messages.
- **Chapter 7: Evaluation and Results** – Presents an analysis of the impact of modified error messages, including both quantitative and qualitative findings.
- **Chapter 8: Conclusion** – Summarizes key findings, discusses their implications, and provides recommendations for future work.
- **Chapter 9: Discussion** – Interprets the results, discusses their significance for programming education, and explores the broader implications of improved error messages.

This structure ensures a logical flow, moving from problem identification to solution development and evaluation, ultimately contributing to a better understanding of how error messages affect novice programmers.

2. Related Work

TODO

Apparently there is something to do.

[Tol12]

2.1. Challenges for Novice Programmers

TODO

Describe common difficulties novices face when learning programming.

2.2. Role of Error Messages in Learning

TODO

Discuss how error messages impact the debugging and learning process.

2.3. Existing Approaches to Improving Error Messages

TODO

Review current solutions and their limitations.

2.4. Educational Feedback Theories

TODO

Summarize relevant feedback theories from educational research.

3. Analysis of Previous Semester Data

TODO

Bla bla bla

In this chapter I will go over the data I analyzed.

3.1. Data Collection and Methodology

The data I analyzed was collected during winter semester 2023/2024. The data was anonymized and forwarded to me by my supervisor.

TODO

(1) Number of students

(2) Average semester (ranging from *lowest* to *highest*)

(3) Total number of submissions

(4) 12 sheets with 16 relevant tasks (programming tasks)

(5) TODO

The relevant part of this data set were the submissions in the following directory structure:

```
/<ExerciseId>/
├── Templates/
│   └── <SheetId>/
│       └── <AssignmentId>/
│           ├── _solution/
│           │   └── <AssignmentName>.fs ............................ SOLUTION
│           └── template/
│               ├── Mini.fs
│               ├── Types.fs
│               ├── <AssignmentName>.fs ........................... TEMPLATE
│               └── Tests.fs ...................................... TESTS
└── Uploads/
    └── <SheetId>/
        └── <GroupId>_<TeamId>/
            └── <AssignmentId>/ ............................... SUBMISSIONS
                ├── <Timestamp>-<AssignmentName>.fs ............... FORMAT
                └── ....................................... OTHER SUBMISSIONS
```

The students were provided with a zip file usually containing `Mini.fs`, `Types.fs` and `<AssignmentName>.fs`. They do not have access to the tests, but they are able to execute them via ExClaim. **`Mini.fs`** is a library of useful methods and basic types that are used throughout all of the assignments. The type `Nat` for example describes a natural number including zero ($\mathbb{N}_0$), written as a non-negative integer with postfix '`N`'. **`Types.fs`** containts assignment specific type definitions, e.g.: Tree representation, Map representation, etc. **`<AssignmentName>.fs`** then contains the methods that are supposed to be implemented. Let's take for example a method that returns the minimum of 3 natural numbers:

Template

```fsharp
let minimumOfThreeNumbers (a: Nat) (b: Nat) (c: Nat): Nat =
    failwith "TODO"
```

The method is implemented with the placeholder `failwith "TODO"` to ensure compilation. The students are supposed to replace the `failwith "TODO"` with their implementation of that method.

Sample Solution

```fsharp
let minimumOfThreeNumbers (a: Nat) (b: Nat) (c: Nat): Nat =
    min (min a b) c
```

In the sample solution the placeholder was replaced by a compact solution for the assignment. Submissions may contain `match`-statements, `if-else`-statements or similar structures, which also valid.

TODO

(1) i also had the timestamps of executed tests and deleted files

(2) Each submission is stored with a timestamp

(3) To analyze this data reconstructed all snapshots during test execution and ran them again inside of docker containers to extract the results of `dotnet build` and `dotnet test`.

3.2. Compilation Success Rates

TODO

Present the success rates for project compilation.

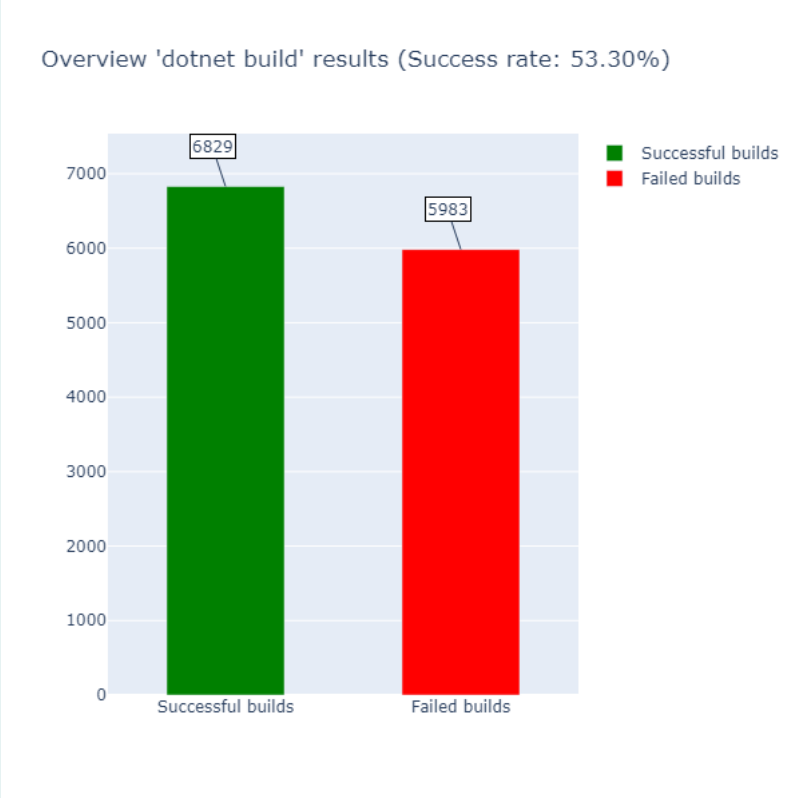

Figure 3.1. Build Stability Analysis: Success and failure counts for .NET builds, with overall success percentage.

3.3. Test Pass Rates

TODO

Analyze the percentage of passed tests.

Figure 3.2. Submission Performance Analysis: Success rate of initial and final submissions across different exercises.

3.4. Insights and Patterns

TODO

Highlight key patterns and findings from the data.

Pos	FSharp Error Code	Short Description & Example
1st	*FS0001*	The type 'X' (e.g. `bool`) does not match the type 'Y' (e.g. `int`). `let x: int = true`

2nd	*FS0058*	Unexpected syntax or possible incorrect indentation.
		`let f x = if x then 1 else`
		`-1`

3rd	*FS0588*	The block following this 'X' (e.g. `let`) is unfinished. Every code block is an expression and must have a result.
		`let add a b =`
		`  let result = a + b`

4th	*FS0597*	Successive arguments should be separated by spaces or tupled, and arguments involving function or method applications should be parenthesized. `printfn "%d" List.min([1; 2])`
5th	*FS3524*	Expecting expression. `if 1 < 2 then 1 else`

6th	*FS3546*	Expecting pattern.
		`type Ex = | A of int * int`
		`match A(1,2) with A (, y) -> y`

7th	*FS0033*	The type 'X' expects m type argument(s) but is given n.
		`type Ex<'a,'b> = {A:'a; B:'b}`
		`let ex: Ex<int> = {A=1; B=2}`

8th	*FS0800*	Invalid use of a type name.
		`type Ex = {A: int; B: int}`
		`let ex = Ex`

9th	*FS3156*	Unexpected token 'X' or incomplete expression. `let add a b = a +`

10th	*FS0727*	This union case expects n arguments in tupled form, but was given m.
		`type Ex = | A of int * int`
		`match A (1, 2) with A x y -> x`

Table 3.1. The top 10 of F# error codes in all submissions

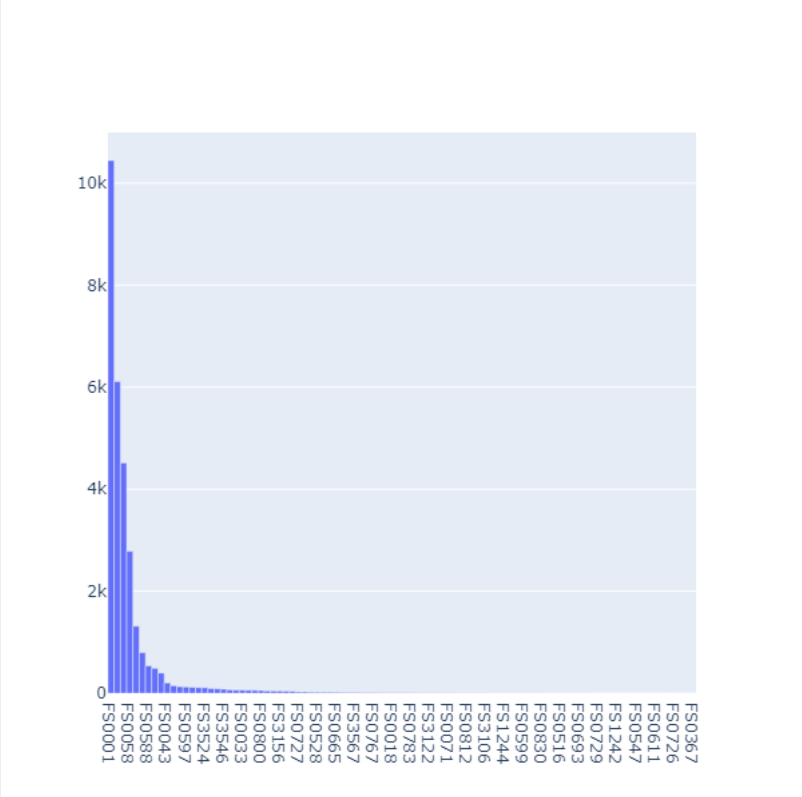

Figure 3.3. Error Code Analysis: Distribution and frequency of `F#` error codes across all exercises and submissions.

4. Problem Analysis: Issues with Existing Error Messages

TODO

Apparently there is something to do.

4.1. Examples of Current Error Messages

TODO

Show examples of unhelpful or ambiguous error messages.

4.1.1. Example 1 — `digitSum`

Implement a method `digitSum: Nat -> Nat`, that takes a natural number `n` as input and returns its digit sum. Examples:

```
digitSum 0N = 0N
digitSum 123N = 6N
digitSum 1234N = 10N
digitSum 4711N = 13N
```

```
let rec digitSum (n: Nat): Nat =
    if n = 0N then
        1N
    else
        (n % 10N) + digitSum (n / 10N)
```

Listing 4.1. Student submission for `digitSum`

```
let rec digitSumSolution (n: Nat): Nat =
    if n = 0N then
        0N
    else
        (n % 10N) + digitSumSolution (n / 10N)
```

Listing 4.2. Sample solution for `digitSum`

Example Tests — digitSum

```
    [<TestMethod>] [<Timeout(1000)>]
    member _.``a) digitSum Examples`` (): unit =
        test <@ digitSum 123N  = 6N @>
        test <@ digitSum 1234N = 10N @>
        test <@ digitSum 42N   = 6N @>
        test <@ digitSum 105N  = 6N @>
        test <@ digitSum 0N    = 0N @>
        test <@ digitSum 4711N = 13N @>
```

Listing 4.3. Example tests for digitSum

```
a) digitSum Examples (388ms): Error Message: Test method Tests+Tests.a)
↪  digitSum Examples threw exception:
    Swensen.Unquote.AssertionFailedException: Test failed:

    StudentSubmission.digitSum 123N = 6N
    StudentSubmission.digitSum 123N = 6N
    7N = 6N
    false

    Stack Trace:
        at Tests.Tests.a) digitSum Examples() in path\to\Tests.fs:line 57
        at System.RuntimeMethodHandle.InvokeMethod(Object target, Void**
        ↪  arguments, Signature sig, Boolean isConstructor)
        at System.Reflection.MethodBaseInvoker.InvokeWithNoArgs(Object obj
        ↪  , BindingFlags invokeAttr)
```

Listing 4.4. Output of examples tests for digitSum

Key Information Example Tests — digitSum

Tested expression	digitSum 123N
Expected result	6N
Actual result	7N

Table 4.1. Key Information Example Tests — digitSum

Random Tests — digitSum

```
    [<TestMethod>] [<Timeout(5000)>]
    member _.``a) digitSum Random`` (): unit =
        Check.One (
            { Config.QuickThrowOnFailure with EndSize = 1000 },
            fun (n: Nat) -> Assert.AreEqual<Nat> (digitSumSolution n,
            ↪  digitSum n)
        )
```

Listing 4.5. Random tests for digitSum

```
a) digitSum Random (74ms): Error Message: Test method Tests+Tests.a)
↪  digitSum Random threw exception:
    System.Exception: Falsifiable, after 1 test (1 shrink) (StdGen (
    ↪  1765833463, 297438798)):
    Original:
    11N
    Shrunk:
    0N
    with exception:
    Microsoft.VisualStudio.TestTools.UnitTesting.AssertFailedException:
    ↪  Assert.AreEqual failed. Expected:<0>. Actual:<1>.
        at Microsoft.VisualStudio.TestTools.UnitTesting.Assert.
        ↪  ThrowAssertFailed(String assertionName, String message) in /_/
        ↪  src/TestFramework/TestFramework/Assertions/Assert.cs:line 60
        at Microsoft.VisualStudio.TestTools.UnitTesting.Assert.AreEqual[T]
        ↪  (T expected, T actual, IEqualityComparer`1 comparer, String
        ↪  message, Object[] parameters) in /_/src/TestFramework/
        ↪  TestFramework/Assertions/Assert.AreEqual.cs:line 201
        at Microsoft.VisualStudio.TestTools.UnitTesting.Assert.AreEqual[T]
        ↪  (T expected, T actual) in /_/src/TestFramework/TestFramework/
        ↪  Assertions/Assert.AreEqual.cs:line 34
        at Tests.a) digitSum Random@69.Invoke(Nat n) in path\to\Tests.fs:
        ↪  line 69
        at FsCheck.Testable.evaluate[a,b](FSharpFunc`2 body, a a)

    Stack Trace:
        at Microsoft.FSharp.Core.PrintfModule.PrintFormatToStringThenFail@
        ↪  1448.Invoke(String message)
        at <StartupCode$FsCheck>.$Runner.get_throwingRunner@382.FsCheck.
        ↪  IRunner.OnFinished(String name, TestResult testResult)
        at FsCheck.Runner.runner[a](Config config, a prop)
        at FsCheck.Runner.check[a](Config config, a p)
        at FsCheck.Check.One[Testable](Config config, Testable property)
        at Tests.Tests.a) digitSum Random() in path\to\Tests.fs:line 68
        at System.RuntimeMethodHandle.InvokeMethod(Object target, Void**
        ↪  arguments, Signature sig, Boolean isConstructor)
        at System.Reflection.MethodBaseInvoker.InvokeWithNoArgs(Object obj
        ↪  , BindingFlags invokeAttr)
```

Listing 4.6. Output of random tests for digitSum

Key Information Random Tests - digitSum

Tested expression	a) digitSum Random Shrunk: 0N } digitSum 0N
Expected result	Expected:<0> ⟹ 0 (actually 0N)
Actual result	Actual:<1> ⟹ 1 (actually 1N)

Table 4.2. Title

4.1.2. Example 2 — sortedDigits

Implement a method `sortedDigits: Nat -> bool`, that takes a natural number `n` as input and returns `true` if the digits are in ascending order and `false` otherwise. Examples:

```
sortedDigits 0N = true
sortedDigits 5N = true
sortedDigits 159N = true
sortedDigits 1111N = true
sortedDigits 1101N = false
sortedDigits 543N = false
```

```
let rec sortedDigits (n: Nat): bool =
    if n = 0N then
        true
    else
        let frontSorted: bool = sortedDigits (n / 10N)
        let lastDigit: Nat = n % 10N
        let secondLastDigit: Nat = (n / 10N) % 10N
        frontSorted && secondLastDigit < lastDigit
```

Listing 4.7. Student submission for sortedDigits

```
let rec sortedDigitsSolution (n: Nat): bool =
    if n = 0N then
        true
    else
        let frontSorted: bool = sortedDigitsSolution (n / 10N)
        let lastDigit: Nat = n % 10N
        let secondLastDigit: Nat = (n / 10N) % 10N
        frontSorted && secondLastDigit <= lastDigit
```

Listing 4.8. Sample solution for sortedDigits

Example Tests — `sortedDigits`

```
    [<TestMethod>] [<Timeout(1000)>]
    member _.``b) sortedDigits Examples`` (): unit =
        test <@ sortedDigits 0N    = true @>
        test <@ sortedDigits 5N    = true @>
        test <@ sortedDigits 159N  = true @>
        test <@ sortedDigits 1111N = true @>
        test <@ sortedDigits 42N   = false @>
        test <@ sortedDigits 543N  = false @>
        test <@ sortedDigits 1101N = false @>
```

Listing 4.9. Example tests for `sortedDigits`

```
b) sortedDigits Examples (4ms): Error Message: Test method Tests+Tests.b)
↪  sortedDigits Examples threw exception:
   Swensen.Unquote.AssertionFailedException: Test failed:

   StudentSubmission.sortedDigits 1111N = true
   StudentSubmission.sortedDigits 1111N = true
   false = true
   false

   Stack Trace:
        at Tests.Tests.b) sortedDigits Examples() in path\to\Tests.fs:line
        ↪   80
        at System.RuntimeMethodHandle.InvokeMethod(Object target, Void**
        ↪  arguments, Signature sig, Boolean isConstructor)
          at System.Reflection.MethodBaseInvoker.InvokeWithNoArgs(Object
          ↪  obj, BindingFlags invokeAttr)
```

Listing 4.10. Output of examples tests for `sortedDigits`

Key Information Example Tests — `sortedDigits`

Tested expression	`sortedDigits 123N`
Expected result	`true`
Actual result	`false`

Table 4.3. Title

Random Tests — `sortedDigits`

```
    [<TestMethod>] [<Timeout(5000)>]
    member _.``b) sortedDigits Random`` (): unit =
        Check.One (
            { Config.QuickThrowOnFailure with EndSize = 1000 },
            fun (n: Nat) -> Assert.AreEqual<bool> (sortedDigitsSolution n,
            ↪   sortedDigits n)
        )
```

Listing 4.11. Random tests for `sortedDigits`

```
b) sortedDigits Random (3ms): Error Message: Test method Tests+Tests.b)
↪  sortedDigits Random threw exception:
  System.Exception: Falsifiable, after 5 tests (0 shrinks) (StdGen (
  ↪  867569077, 297439050)):
  Original:
  33N
  with exception:
  Microsoft.VisualStudio.TestTools.UnitTesting.AssertFailedException:
  ↪  Assert.AreEqual failed. Expected:<True>. Actual:<False>.
        at Microsoft.VisualStudio.TestTools.UnitTesting.Assert.
        ↪  ThrowAssertFailed(String assertionName, String message) in /
        ↪  _/src/TestFramework/TestFramework/Assertions/Assert.cs:line
        ↪  60
        at Microsoft.VisualStudio.TestTools.UnitTesting.Assert.AreEqual[
        ↪  T](T expected, T actual, IEqualityComparer`1 comparer,
        ↪  String message, Object[] parameters) in /_/src/TestFramework
        ↪  /TestFramework/Assertions/Assert.AreEqual.cs:line 201
      at Microsoft.VisualStudio.TestTools.UnitTesting.Assert.AreEqual[T]
      ↪  (T expected, T actual) in /_/src/TestFramework/TestFramework/
      ↪  Assertions/Assert.AreEqual.cs:line 34
        at Tests.b) sortedDigits Random@90.Invoke(Nat n) in path\to\
        ↪  Tests.fs:line 90
        at FsCheck.Testable.evaluate[a,b](FSharpFunc`2 body, a a)

  Stack Trace:
      at Microsoft.FSharp.Core.PrintfModule.PrintFormatToStringThenFail@
      ↪  1448.Invoke(String message)
      at <StartupCode$FsCheck>.$Runner.get_throwingRunner@382.FsCheck.
      ↪  IRunner.OnFinished(String name, TestResult testResult)
        at FsCheck.Runner.runner[a](Config config, a prop)
        at FsCheck.Runner.check[a](Config config, a p)
        at FsCheck.Check.One[Testable](Config config, Testable property)
        at Tests.Tests.b) sortedDigits Random() in path\to\Tests.fs:line
        ↪   89
        at System.RuntimeMethodHandle.InvokeMethod(Object target, Void**
        ↪   arguments, Signature sig, Boolean isConstructor)
        at System.Reflection.MethodBaseInvoker.InvokeWithNoArgs(Object
        ↪  obj, BindingFlags invokeAttr)
```

Listing 4.12. Output of random tests for `sortedDigits`

Tested expression	`b) sortedDigits Random` / `Original: 33N` } `sortedDigits 33N`
Expected result	`Expected:<True>` $\Longrightarrow$ `True` (actually `true`)
Actual result	`Actual:<False>` $\Longrightarrow$ `False` (actually `false`)

Table 4.4. Title

Key Information Random Tests — `sortedDigits`

4.2. Information Gaps in Error Outputs

TODO

Analyze what critical information is missing in these messages.

4.3. Challenges for Novices in Deriving Test Information

TODO

Explain why deciphering test expectations is hard for beginners.

5. Assertify: A Library for Improving Error Messages

Assertify describes a library of various methods and classes to improve error messages during testing.

5.1. Objectives and Design of Assertify

Assertify incorporates functionalities to enhance the debugging and testing experience by providing clearer, more informative error messages. Traditional assertion failures often yield cryptic outputs, making it difficult to identify the root cause of an issue. Assertify addresses this by offering detailed, structured feedback, including expression simplifications, expected vs. actual values, and reduction history. The design principles behind Assertify focus on:

(1) **Clarity** – Displaying test failures in a structured and easily readable format.

(2) **Context** – Providing additional context through expression reductions and history tracking.

(3) **Usability** – Ensuring that error messages are helpful for students and developers alike.

(4) **Flexibility** – Supporting different levels of verbosity for various debugging needs.

By integrating these principles, Assertify streamlines the debugging process and improves the efficiency of error resolution.

5.2. Implementation Details and Wrappers

Assertify is implemented as a wrapper around standard test assertions, enriching the output with structured details. The core mechanism involves capturing the tested expressions, simplifying them where possible, and formatting the results into a well-structured report. Key implementation details include:

- **Expression Reduction:** Assertify simplifies complex expressions, stripping unnecessary details while preserving meaningful structure.
- **History Tracking:** The system logs successfully evaluated expressions leading up to a failure, providing insight into the progression of computations. This is especially helpful if a succession of operations are executed on the

same data structure and said data structure is correctly implemented for the majority of operations and only fails when a specific edge case occurs (e.g. an (almost) full linked list encounters a out-of-bounds index error). Then the history of operations might be helpful for novices to recreate the error because the order of operations is crutial to whether or not a operation fails.

- **Verbose and Compact Modes:** Users can toggle between detailed explanations and minimalistic outputs.
- **Enhanced Formatting:** Utilizing structured markers and color-coded elements, Assertify highlights critical differences between expected and actual results.

By wrapping around existing test frameworks, Assertify seamlessly integrates into existing workflows, enhancing error visibility without requiring significant changes to test code.

5.3. Error Message Improvements (Before and After Comparisons)

Traditional assertion failures often return extremely detailed messages that require additional effort to decipher. Assertify enhances this by providing detailed comparisons. The enhanced output not only shows expected vs. actual values but also presents the exact expression tested, making debugging significantly easier.

5.3.1. Example 1 — `digitSum`

TODO

Apparently there is something to do.

Example Tests — `digitSum`

TODO

(1) Compare old and new test results (old: 4.4.)

```
-------------------- TESTED EXPRESSION -----------------------
Tested/Failed expression:   StudentSubmission.digitSum 123N
Simplified expression:      digitSum 123N
------------------- EXPECTED AND ACTUAL ----------------------
Expected result:            6N
Actual result:              7N
```

Listing 5.1. Assertify output of examples tests for `digitSum`

Random Tests — `digitSum`

TODO

(1) Compare old and new test results (old: 4.6.)

```
-------------------- TESTED EXPRESSION -----------------------
Tested/Failed expression:   StudentSubmission.digitSum n
Simplified expression:      digitSum 0N
------------------- EXPECTED AND ACTUAL ----------------------
Expected result:            0N
Actual result:              1N
```

Listing 5.2. Assertify output of examples tests for `digitSum`

5.3.2. Example 2 — `sortedDigits`

TODO

Apparently there is something to do.

Example Tests — `sortedDigits`

TODO

(1) Compare old and new test results (old: 4.10.)

```
-------------------- TESTED EXPRESSION -------------------------
Tested/Failed expression:   StudentSubmission.sortedDigits 1111N
Simplified expression:      sortedDigits 1111N
------------------- EXPECTED AND ACTUAL ------------------------
Expected result:            true
Actual result:              false
```

Listing 5.3. Assertify output of examples tests for `sortedDigits`

Random Tests — `sortedDigits`

TODO

(1) Compare old and new test results (old: 4.12.)

```
-------------------- TESTED EXPRESSION -----------------------
Tested/Failed expression:   StudentSubmission.sortedDigits n
Simplified expression:      sortedDigits 33N
------------------- EXPECTED AND ACTUAL ---------------------
Expected result:            true
Actual result:              false
```

Listing 5.4. Assertify output of examples tests for `sortedDigits`

5.4. Usability and Design Considerations

Assertify is designed with a strong focus on usability, particularly for students learning programming and debugging. Key considerations include:

- **Readable Error Reports:** Formatting failures in a structured, natural-language format ensures accessibility.
- **Minimal Intrusion:** Assertify seamlessly integrates with existing test frameworks without requiring major changes.

- **Customizability:** Users can adjust verbosity levels and enable/disable history tracking based on their needs.
- **Color Coding and Annotations:** Highlighting key differences improves readability and makes debugging more intuitive.

These design choices collectively improve the debugging experience, reducing frustration and helping developers quickly understand and fix issues.

6. TODO: Further Methodology (unclear what comes next)

TODO

(1) VS Code Extension

(2) ExClaim Embedding

7. Evaluation and Results

TODO

Apparently there is something to do.

7.1. Evaluation Methodology

TODO

Explain how you assessed the effectiveness of Assertify.

7.2. Metrics for Success

TODO

Describe the criteria used to measure improvements.

7.3. Quantitative Analysis

TODO

Present the data and statistical results.

7.4. Qualitative Insights

TODO

Share insights from student feedback or observations.

7.5. Comparison to Previous Results

TODO

Highlight improvements compared to the baseline semester data.

8. Conclusion

TODO

Apparently there is something to do.

8.1. Summary of Contributions

TODO

Recap your key contributions.

8.2. Key Findings

TODO

Highlight the most important results and insights.

8.3. Suggestions for Future Work

TODO

Provide ideas for continued research and development.

9. Discussion

TODO

Apparently there is something to do.

9.1. Interpretation of Results

TODO

Analyze what the results reveal about error messages and learning.

9.2. Impact on Learning Process

TODO

Discuss how Assertify influenced students' debugging and comprehension.

9.3. Strengths and Limitations of Approach

TODO

Identify the strengths and potential weaknesses of the approach.

9.4. Recommendations for Future Development

TODO

Suggest possible extensions or refinements.

List of Figures

3.1. Build Stability Analysis 7
3.2. Submission Performance Analysis 8
3.3. Error Code Analysis 11

List of Listings

4.1. Student submission for `digitSum` 14
4.2. Sample solution for `digitSum` 14
4.3. Example tests for `digitSum` 15
4.4. Output of examples tests for `digitSum` 15
4.5. Random tests for `digitSum` 16
4.6. Output of random tests for `digitSum` 16
4.7. Student submission for `sortedDigits` 17
4.8. Sample solution for `sortedDigits` 17
4.9. Example tests for `sortedDigits` 18
4.10. Output of examples tests for `sortedDigits` 18
4.11. Random tests for `sortedDigits` 19
4.12. Output of random tests for `sortedDigits` 19

5.1. Assertify output of examples tests for `digitSum` 23
5.2. Assertify output of examples tests for `digitSum` 23
5.3. Assertify output of examples tests for `sortedDigits` 24
5.4. Assertify output of examples tests for `sortedDigits` 24

List of Tables

3.1. The top 10 of `F#` error codes in all submissions 10

4.1. Key Information Example Tests — `digitSum` 15
4.2. Title 17
4.3. Title 18
4.4. Title 20

A. My Code

TODO

Put detailed code here.

B. My Ideas

TODO

Ideas??

Bibliography

[Tol12] J.R.R. Tolkien. *The Lord of the Rings: One Volume*. The Lord of the Rings. Houghton Mifflin Harcourt, 2012. ISBN: 9780547951942.